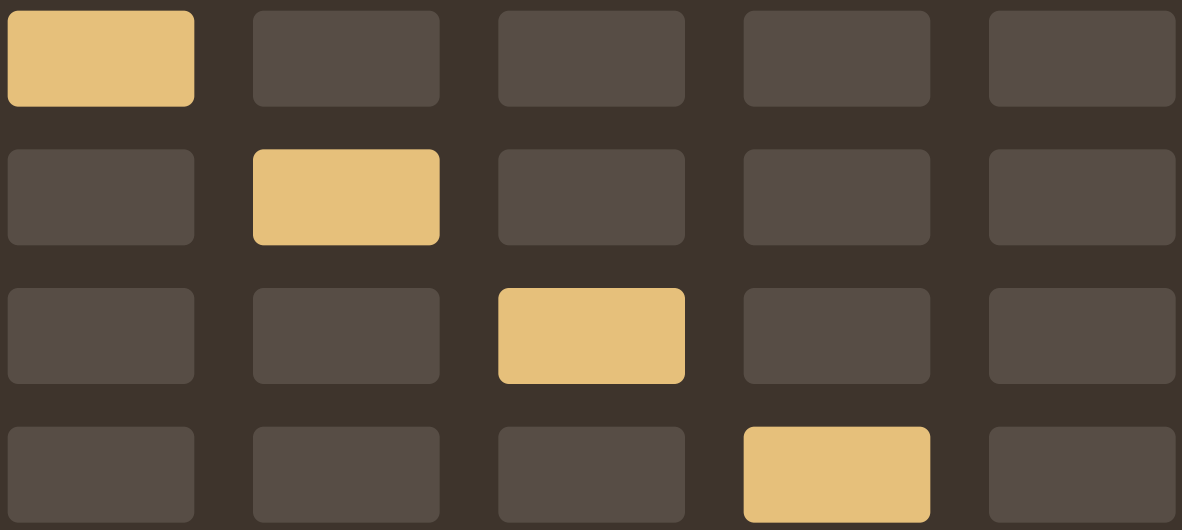
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PRODUCTIVITY

The Habit Ledger

Habits and time, one page



A DIGITAL GUIDE

The Habit Ledger

Pick fewer habits. Attach them to cues you already have. Review the week on one page. That is the whole method.

A missed day is part of the practice. The restart chapter is not optional reading.

> A note on limits. This guide describes methods. It cannot see your course, your calendar, or your life. Use what fits. Leave what does not. Nothing here guarantees a grade, a streak, or a particular outcome.

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01

How to use this guide

Choose the habits before you design a beautiful spread. The printable pages at the end are blank on purpose. If you fill them with twelve ambitions, you have recreated the problem this guide is for.

- One to three active habits.
- A cue that already happens.
- Two time blocks that can survive a bad week.
- One weekly review, thirty minutes or less.

02

Pick fewer habits

A keystone habit makes other things easier: a walk, a shutdown ritual at the end of work, a regular bedtime, ten minutes of practice for a skill that pays you. Most other wishes are projects. Projects get a deadline. Habits get a cue. Mixing them is how a list becomes a verdict on your character.

Write the candidates. Circle the one that, if it happened, would make the others less necessary. That is the first habit. You may add a second if it lives in a different part of the day. A third is allowed only after two weeks in which the first two mostly happened.

Wish	Treat it as	Because
Run a race	Project, with a date	It ends
Walk after lunch	Habit	It can repeat forever
Inbox zero	Standard, not a habit	It is a description of work
Read 20 pages	Habit, if the cue is real	Otherwise it is a hope

03

Design the cue

A cue is something that already happens: the kettle, the end of a meeting, putting the child to bed, closing the laptop. Attach the habit to it in one sentence. 'After I close the laptop, I write tomorrow's first task.' If the sentence needs a mood, it is not designed yet.

Friction is the rest of the design. Put the shoes by the door. Leave the book on the pillow you will move. Remove the app from the first screen if the habit is 'do not open it.' Environment beats a speech you give yourself.

- [ ] The cue already happens on the days I care about.
- [ ] The habit starts in under two minutes.
- [ ] The materials are where the cue is.
- [ ] I removed one piece of friction, not ten.

> **Try this.** Make the habit smaller before you make the cue clever. Two minutes of the real habit beats a complicated system for a habit you have not started.

04

Time blocks for a real week

A time block is a draft. Protect two of them: one for the work that needs a quiet hour, one for the life task that otherwise lands at 10 p.m. Leave slack around them. A calendar with no slack is a fiction, and you will abandon it on the first day someone is sick.

Week shape	Block to protect	Slack you must leave
Office days	One deep hour before meetings	A buffer after lunch
Shift work	The hour after sleep, not 'evening'	A day with nothing new
Caregiving	The nap or the school block	One evening with no habit

Put the habit inside a block only if it needs time. A two-minute cue does not need a block. Giving it one makes it look optional and large.

05

The weekly review

Same time each week. Thirty minutes. You are not journaling your entire life. You are deciding what next week is for.

- [ ] Which habits happened, and on which days.
- [ ] Which cue failed, and whether the cue was the problem.
- [ ] What must move on the calendar.
- [ ] One thing to drop.
- [ ] The two blocks for next week, written.
- [ ] Stop.

> **Try this.** If you miss the review, do a five-minute version the next morning: habits, one drop, two blocks. Do not wait for a free Sunday that is not coming.

06

When you miss

Missing is the data. A habit that fails every Wednesday has a Wednesday problem: the cue does not exist that day, or the day is already full. Change the cue or shrink the habit. Do not start a new tracker to punish the miss.

Do not treat day 21, or any fixed day, as the day a habit becomes automatic. A review in the British Journal of General Practice, checked for this edition, reports an average near 66 days in one study, a wide spread, and that an occasional miss did not erase progress. That average is not your target. Restart at the next cue. If the same day fails every week, the cue is the question. Answer it in one sentence on the ledger.

- Restart at the next cue, not next Monday.
- Do the two-minute version if the full version feels ruined.
- Do not add a replacement habit to 'make up for it.'
- If you are ill, the habit is paused. Write 'paused.'

07

A thirty-day starter

Days 1 to 7: one habit, two-minute version, cue written on the page. Days 8 to 14: keep it, and add the weekly review. Days 15 to 21: if the first habit happened on at least four days each week, add a second. Days 22 to 30: hold. Do not add a third yet.

Days	Habits allowed	Review	Success looks like
1 to 7	One, tiny	Optional note	The cue fired
8 to 14	One	First real review	You can name the cue
15 to 21	Two, if the first held	Weekly	Four days each
22 to 30	Hold	Weekly	No new systems

08

Printable ledger pages

Copy this page three times if you want a month on paper. One row is a day. The checkbox is the tiny version. The note is optional and should be one line.

Day	Habit 1	Habit 2	Block kept?	One line
Mon	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]	
Tue	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]	
Wed	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]	
Thu	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]	
Fri	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]	

Day	Habit 1	Habit 2	Block kept?	One line
Sat	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]	
Sun	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]	Review

Weekly page

- ☐ Habits that happened often enough to keep.
- ☐ Cue to change.
- ☐ One drop.
- ☐ Two blocks next week.
- ☐ Anything that needs a project plan instead of a habit.

09

A worked example

E works rotating shifts and had a list of eleven habits, which is a wish list. The ledger cut it to one: after the shoes come off, a two-minute stretch and a glass of water. The cue existed on every kind of day. The habit was small enough to survive a night shift.

Week 2 added the weekly review, done after the longer sleep, not on a fictional Sunday. The review dropped 'read twenty pages' because it had no cue. It kept the stretch. Week 3 added a second habit: when the shift schedule is posted, copy next week's two protected blocks onto a card. That is a calendar habit, not a personality.

E missed four days during a run of nights and restarted at the next shoe-off, not the next month. The thirty-day page shows gaps. The gaps are why the page is honest. At day 30 the stretch was mostly there and the blocks were written. A third habit waited. The waiting was the method.

If your week does not look like this one, do not force the resemblance. Copy the structure: a baseline, one change at a time, a written review, and a stop when the tool is the wrong tool. The names above are teaching composites, not testimonials and not promises.

10

Field pages

Three habits is the cap. If you need a fourth row, you are collecting wishes. Turn the extra into a project with an end date or delete it.

Cue design

Habit	Cue that already happens	Two-minute version	Friction I removed
1			
2			
3			

Thirty days

Day	H1	H2	H3	Note
1				
2				
3				
4				
5				
6				
7				
8				
9				
10				
11				
12				
13				
14				
15				

Copy the table for days 16 to 30. Do not add a habit in the second half unless the first survived four days a week.

- ☐ Weekly review happened.
- ☐ I dropped one thing.
- ☐ Two blocks are written for next week.
- ☐ A miss was restarted at the next cue.

11

Thirty-day log

This log is the part you write. Print it. A guide you only read is a brochure. Thirty lines is a month, and a month is long enough to see whether the method fits.

Days 1 to 15

Day	Cue	Habit 1	Habit 2	Review	Note
1					
2					
3					
4					
5					
6					
7					
8					
9					
10					
11					
12					
13					
14					
15					

Do not backfill a day you forgot. Leave it blank. A blank line is more useful next month than a number you invented. The lines are tall enough to write in, not just to type a checkmark.

Days 16 to 30

Day	Cue	Habit 1	Habit 2	Review	Note
16					

Day	Cue	Habit 1	Habit 2	Review	Note
17					
18					
19					
20					
21					
22					
23					
24					
25					
26					
27					
28					
29					
30					

Weekly notes

Week	What repeated	What I will change
1		
2		
3		
4		

Week	What repeated	What I will change
5		

Open notes

	Write in the lines

End of the month

Question	Your answer
What actually repeated?	
What did I abandon, and should it stay abandoned?	
What is the one change for next month?	

Question	Your answer
Do I need a person, not a PDF?	
Where is the file saved on my own device?	

- ☐ I can find this PDF without the download link.
- ☐ The license is mine. I have not posted the file.
- ☐ Next month's first action is written in one sentence.
- ☐ If the guide was the wrong tool, I know what I will do instead.

A last word

Use the pages that match the week you are actually having. Print a worksheet if paper helps you tell the truth. Put the file somewhere you can find it. And if a chapter tells you to talk to a licensed professional, that instruction outranks the rest of the PDF.